The Weirdest & Most Shocking Facts

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THE MONSTER EL NIÑO

1. **Corpses were bricked into homes so neighbours wouldn't eat them.** The 1877–78 super El Niño caused a global famine that may have killed **50 million** people. People ate mud, tree roots, pets and leather; children were sold for a meal; families burned their own houses for warmth. [p.6]
2. **The current El Niño is the strongest ever recorded – and it hasn't even peaked.** Scientists (not the media) are calling it “mind-blowing”, “off the charts” and “Godzilla-level”. [p.4]
3. **The ocean literally piles up.** Before an El Niño, winds stack warm water so high that sea level in the western Pacific rises by up to 20 cm. The warm layer is now more than **80 metres deeper** than normal in places. [p.4]
4. **A desert turned into a lake.** During the 1998 super El Niño, rain turned a Peruvian desert into a lake. East Africa got rain up to **100 times** the average, sparking malaria and Rift Valley fever. [p.5]
5. **The 1997 El Niño ended “with a bang”** – sea temperatures in the eastern Pacific crashed by **8°C in a single month**. [p.11]
6. **2027 is expected to be the hottest year in human history**, because El Niño's heat takes 3–4 months to spread on top of global warming. [p.7]
7. **Some places will never go back.** Scientists warn this El Niño may push parts of the Earth system across “regime-shift” thresholds – the climate there will never return to how it was. [p.6]

CRAZY IDEAS TO FIGHT IT

8. **5.8 million km of pipe.** Cooling just the Indian Ocean by pumping up cold deep water would need nearly **double the length of every pipeline on Earth**. [p.10]
9. **Robots that raise the ground.** A California start-up injects wood-waste slurry 12–18 m underground to lift land by about **30 cm per day** to beat floods. [p.11]
10. **Sunscreen for coral reefs.** A film just **one molecule thick**, floated on the sea, cut light reaching corals by 30%. Floating shade hexagons are being tested in Florida. [p.11]
11. **A rice gene that survives a week underwater** (SUB1) is already in crops worldwide; a heat-tolerant rice gene gave **31–78% higher yields** in hot trials. [p.11]

FOOD SHOCK

12. **Your coffee and chocolate are in danger.** All four top coffee producers usually suffer El Niño drought – Arabica prices have already jumped **30%**. Chocolate could rise too. [p.8]

13. **A UK minister told Britons to stockpile food**; the climate minister replied she always has “a few cans of beans” anyway. [p.9]

14. **274 million people** in 45 countries are expected to be acutely food insecure by the end of 2027 – 49 million more than today. [p.10]

AI GONE WILD

15. **OpenAI dumped 722 maths papers in one go**, claiming to crack hundreds of unsolved problems. Three had already been retracted before the magazine went to press. [p.12]

16. **25 years of work – solved by a machine.** A UCL mathematician spent 25 years and wrote two books on Wall's D(2) problem, then gave up. The AI solved it. [p.12]

17. **10,000 AI agents vs. one equation.** OpenAI threw 10,000 agents and millions of dollars at the Navier–Stokes problem. The result: a “hilariously ugly” 166-page proof nobody can explain – and a **$1 million prize nobody wants to collect**. [p.19]

18. **The world's tiniest speed-up.** One AI paper makes multiplication faster by 2^{-182} – less than 1 / 14 million billion billion billion of the age of the universe for a 1 ms sum. [p.12]

19. **Two rival AIs teamed up** (Anthropic's Claude Fable and OpenAI's GPT-6 Astra) and found the largest symmetrical Venn diagram ever – 17 sets – in two days, then 19 sets by Sunday. [p.12]

20. **An AI's secret “thoughts”.** Researchers can read Claude's inner “J-space”. Fed fake search results, it secretly thought “fraud” and “fake” but didn't say it. Told not to think about the Golden Gate Bridge, its hidden thoughts contained the bridge – and the word **“damn”**. [p.34]

21. **Swap one hidden word, change its mind.** Changing “Spanish” to “French” inside Claude made it translate “hello” as bonjour and name Victor Hugo as a famous author. [p.34]

YOUR BODY

22. **Clogged arteries in your 20s.** In a study of ~17,000 people, nearly **1 in 10** adults aged 18–29 already had artery plaque; **35% of men in their 30s** did. Overall 57% had “silent” plaque. [p.14]

23. **Babies who got zero sugar live longer – 70 years later.** UK babies under 2 were allocated no sugar during post-war rationing. Today they are more likely to be alive, are biologically younger and have younger hearts, lungs and livers. [p.20]

24. **Baby food sugar bomb:** experts say under-2s should eat less than 15 g of free sugar a day – yet many baby snacks contain close to **15 g in a single serving**. [p.21]

25. **Tattoos you can switch off.** New “PhotoTat” ink: UV light writes the colour in, bright light erases it – repeatably. The inventor has worn one for two years. [p.16]

CANCER BREAKTHROUGHS

26. **Pancreatic cancer – the “worst of the worst” – beaten by genes.** Over 30% of patients matched to a gene-targeted treatment are alive after 5 years, versus just 4% without a match. [p.38]

27. **A robot tests 100+ drugs on a child's own cancer cells** grown in a lab, or the cancer is grown inside a mouse to test a drug first. [p.39]

28. **Chemo by accident:** cisplatin was discovered by scientists playing with platinum electrodes and bacteria; paclitaxel came from the bark of the Pacific yew tree. [p.36]

29. **The doctor became his own patient.** The pioneer who set up Australia's national program was diagnosed with cancer and enrolled in his own program. [p.39]

ANIMALS, FOSSILS & SPACE

30. **A 194-year-old tortoise with the cells of a toddler.** Jonathan, the oldest known land animal, has mitochondrial genes as efficient as a **5-year-old** tortoise's, and 287 genes unique to him. [p.16]

31. **Asteroids spinning every 5 minutes.** Two space rocks over 2 km wide spin so fast they should fly apart – they must be solid blocks at least 30× stronger than clay. [p.15]

32. **Neanderthals lived in a “wooden age”.** Almost 600 wooden objects (40,000–62,000 years old) include spears, trays, a mystery tripod and a club unlike anything ever found. [p.15]

33. **The first mammal to suckle** lived 163–168 million years ago: rear half like a platypus, head like an otter. [p.13]

34. **A giant waterlily discovered thanks to social media.** A carnivorous-plant seller posted holiday swimming photos; Kew scientists spotted a new species with leaves up to 3 m wide. [p.14]

35. **Snow leopards can't roar – they “sing”.** And Indigenous people described the **sound of the northern lights** long before scientists recorded it. [p.27]

36. **Crocodile tears are real** – crocodiles really can appear to cry while eating, but it has nothing to do with emotion. [p.46]

37. **The Roman telescope gathers 1000 years of Hubble data every 10 months.** [p.41]

JUST PLAIN WEIRD

38. **A Star Trek casserole dish was flown to 35 km altitude** by balloon to advertise Le Creuset cookware – including a mug with a Spock-ear handle. [p.48]

39. **Who thinks they're hottest?** A study found high self-rated attractiveness is linked to being male, having a degree – and slightly lower cognitive ability. [p.48]

40. **Indexing fail:** “Atherosclerotic tendencies in monks” got split by a computer into “ATHEROSCL EROTIC TENDENCIES IN MONKS”. [p.48]